

initially learned mainly about church music. However, in 1861, a new piano teacher, Camille Saint-Saëns, introduced Gabriel to the modern composers who would come to exert a strong influence on his style.

After leaving school, Fauré worked as a church organist while also taking on pupils. His first official post was at St. Sauveur in Rennes, where he had an extremely rocky relationship with the local priest, and was finally asked to leave after showing up for Sunday service in full evening dress, having been out all night at a ball.

“ For me ... **music exists to elevate us as far as possible above everyday existence.**
”

GABRIEL FAURE, LETTER TO HIS SON, PHILIPPE,
1908

Recognition and royalties

After volunteering for service in the Franco-Prussian War and fighting in the Siege of Paris, Fauré resumed his musical career, eventually becoming the choirmaster and chief organist at the Madeleine, a famous Parisian church. Fauré saw this prestigious post as his “mercenary job” because it left him so little time to compose. Lack of time and money were perennial problems for him. He only rarely received royalties for his music, instead